KPPSC PMS • GEOGRAPHY (PAPER-II)

EXECUTIVE MASTER EXAMINATION NOTES • Q.6: Migration Dynamics: Internal & International Migration, Push-Pull Models & Socio-Economic Impact

Target Examination	KPPSC PMS (Provincial Management Service) — Khyber Pakhtunkhwa
Paper & Subject	Geography Paper-II (Human, Economic & Regional Geography — 100 Marks)
EXAM QUESTIONS LINKED:	• 2018 Q.8(d): "Write short note on: Trends and patterns of population migration in Pakistan. (10 Marks)" • 2016 Q.7: "Explain the causes and socio-economic consequences of international migration (push-pull factors, remittances, brain drain). (20 Marks)" • 2013 Q.5: "Elaborate pioneer settlement patterns. \"The pattern of settlement characterizing human use of the earth is strongly related to migration.\" Discuss. (20 Marks)" • 2010 Q.8(a): "Write note on: Rural-urban migration. (10 Marks)"
Syllabus Section	Section A & C: Human Geography — Types of migration, push and pull factors, economic impacts, regional migration in Pakistan
Allocated Marks & Time	20 Marks | 35 Minutes Exam Writing Allocation
Core Analytical Thesis	Human migration represents a fundamental spatial equalization mechanism driven by geographic disparities in economic opportunity, ecological security, and political stability. Conceptualized theoretically by E.G. Ravenstein's Laws, Everett Lee's Push-Pull framework, and Wilbur Zelinsky's Mobility Transition Model, migration in Pakistan manifests in two dominant spatial corridors: internal rural-to-urban drift that concentrates labor in coastal and industrial primate cities, and international circular labor migration to the Persian Gulf that generates an indispensable remittance lifeline ($30+ billion annually) while creating structural 'Dutch disease' distortions and regional brain drain.

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📌 EXAM ESSENTIAL TAKEAWAY

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK: Everett Lee's Push-Pull Model identifies four factors: factors associated with the area of origin (push), factors associated with the destination (pull), intervening obstacles (distance, physical barriers, immigration laws, cost), and personal factors.

RAVENSTEIN'S LAWS OF MIGRATION: Formulated in 1885, establishing that most migrants travel short distances, migration occurs in steps, long-distance migrants head for major commercial centers, rural residents are more migratory than urban, and economic motives predominate.

INTERNAL DRIFT IN PAKISTAN: Characterized by massive rural-urban movement from the impoverished hinterlands of southern Punjab, rural Sindh, and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa into megacities like Karachi, Lahore, Faisalabad, and Rawalpindi-Islamabad, driven by rural mechanization, landlessness, and climate disasters.

THE GULF REMITTANCE CORRIDOR: Over 9 million Pakistani overseas workers (overwhelmingly in Saudi Arabia, UAE, and GCC nations) remit over $30 billion annually, providing essential balance-of-payments support,

> particularly transforming the rural economies of KP (Peshawar, Mardan, Swat) and Northern Punjab.

1. CONCEPTUAL MIND MAP & THEMATIC ROADMAP

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SPATIAL MOBILITY AND MIGRATION SYSTEM (THEORY & PAKISTAN CORRIDORS)
=================================================================================================
[1. THEORETICAL FOUNDATIONS OF MIGRATION]
  ├── E.G. Ravenstein (1885): "Laws of Migration"
  │     ├── Distance Decay: Volume of migration decreases as distance increases.
  │     ├── Step Migration: Rural migrants move to local market towns, then provincial cities, then primate
megacities.
  │     └── Economic Predominance: The economic motive is the primary, overwhelming driver of spatial reallocation.
  ├── Everett S. Lee (1966): "Push-Pull Theory"
  │     [Origin (Push)] ──► [Intervening Obstacles (Cost, Border, Distance)] ──► [Destination (Pull)]
  └── Wilbur Zelinsky (1971): "Mobility Transition Model" (Parallels DTM)
        ├── Phase 2 (Developing): Massive rural-to-urban migration and international emigration.
        └── Phase 4 (Developed): Inter-urban and intra-urban mobility; international immigration.
        │
        ▼ (The Pakistan Migration Matrix)
[2. INTERNAL MIGRATORY DYNAMICS IN PAKISTAN]
  ├── RURAL-TO-URBAN DRIFT (The Dominant Internal Flow)
  │     ├── Push Factors: Landlessness, agricultural mechanization, feudal tenancy, 2022 floods/droughts, lack of
colleges/clinics.
  │     ├── Pull Factors: Informal wage jobs, construction labor, tertiary service opportunities, educational hubs.
  │     └── Receiving Hubs: Karachi (the national magnet), Lahore, Faisalabad, Gujranwala, Peshawar.
  └── CONFLICT & CLIMATE-INDUCED DISPLACEMENT
        ├── Internal Displacement (IDPs): KP & Merged Districts (Swat 2009, Zarb-e-Azb 2014) caused temporary urban
exodus.
        └── Climate Displacement: Indus Basin floods (2010, 2022) displaced millions, permanently accelerating urban
migration.
        │
        ▼ (International Transnational Corridors)
[3. INTERNATIONAL EMIGRATION & REMITTANCE GEOGRAPHY]
  ├── GCC / Middle East Corridor (~60% of Total Emigrants):
  │     ├── Profile: Temporary, circular, male-dominated, semi-skilled/unskilled (construction, transport, services).
  │     ├── Destinations: Saudi Arabia (KSA), United Arab Emirates (UAE), Qatar, Oman, Kuwait.
  │     └── Primary Origin Zones: Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (Swat, Dir, Mardan, Kohat) and Northern Punjab (Rawalpindi,
Gujrat).
  └── Western / OECD Corridor (~30% of Total Emigrants):
        ├── Profile: Permanent, skilled/educated professionals, family reunification, student pathways.
        ├── Destinations: United Kingdom, United States, Canada, European Union, Australia.
        └── Ramifications: Massive intellectual capital loss ('Brain Drain') vs. stable diaspora political lobbying.
        │
        ▼
[4. THE REFUGEE GEOGRAPHY: AFGHAN PROTRACTED CRISIS]
  * Pakistan hosts ~1.4 to 3 million Afghan refugees across 4 decades (post-1979 Soviet invasion to post-2021 Taliban
return).
  * Spatial Footprint: Heavy concentration in KP (Peshawar, Nowshera, Haripur) and Balochistan (Quetta, Chaman,
Pishin).
  * Socio-Economic Impact: Commercial dynamism (transport, rug trade) vs. strain on municipal infrastructure, security
friction.
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2. ANALYTICAL DIMENSIONS & SOCIO-SPATIAL/THEORETICAL MATRIX

Migration Corridor / Type	Core Push & Pull Factors	Spatial Trajectory in Pakistan	Socio-Economic Balance Sheet
Internal Rural-Urban Drift	Push: Rural poverty, landlessness, climate shocks. Pull: Industrial jobs, informal services, urban anonymity.	From rural Sindh/Punjab/KP into Karachi, Lahore, Faisalabad, Peshawar.	Positive: Labor supply for industry. Negative: Growth of slums (katchi abadis), brain drain from rural farming, urban smog.
GCC Contract Labor Emigration	Push: Low domestic wages, unemployment. Pull: High petrodollar wages, family prestige, capital accumulation.	From KP (Swat, Dir, Peshawar) and Central/North Punjab to Saudi Arabia and UAE.	Positive: Generates $30B+ remittances, poverty reduction in villages. Negative: 'Dutch disease', family separation, male absence.
Skilled OECD Emigration	Push: Political instability, economic stagnation, security	From major urban centers (Karachi, Lahore, Islamabad)	Positive: Diaspora investments, academic linkages. Negative: Acute

Migration Corridor / Type	Core Push & Pull Factors	Spatial Trajectory in Pakistan	Socio-Economic Balance Sheet
('Brain Drain')	concerns. Pull: High wages, career growth, citizenship.	to UK, USA, Canada, EU.	loss of doctors, IT specialists, engineers, and educators.
Afghan Refugee Influx	Push: Foreign invasions (1979, 2001), civil war, Taliban resurgence. Pull: Ethnic Pashtun kinship, geographic proximity.	Cross-Durand Line flows into KP (Peshawar, tribal districts) and Balochistan.	Positive: Rejuvenated transport, wholesale, and manual labor markets. Negative: Deforestation in border belts, civic infrastructure saturation.
Internal Climate Displacement	Push: Monsoon catastrophic floods, glacial lake outburst floods (GLOFs), sea intrusion in Indus Delta.	From rural Sindh (Dadu, Khairpur) and South Punjab to urban relief camps and cities.	Permanent displacement of rural poor; accelerated urbanization of destitute climate refugees without urban skills.

3. 20-MARK MASTER MODEL ESSAY (KPPSC PMS BENCHMARK)

Introduction: Migration as a Spatial and Socio-Economic Equalizer

Migration—the permanent or semi-permanent change of residence by an individual or group across administrative or political boundaries—is one of the most fundamental processes in human geography. It represents a spatial response to uneven development, geographical inequalities in resource distribution, and differential economic opportunities. Far from being a random or chaotic movement of people, migration is a structured geographical process governed by distinct spatial laws and behavioral dynamics. In Pakistan, migration operates as both an engine of economic survival and a symptom of deep structural crises, linking remote agrarian villages in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa to the global petrodollar circuits of the Persian Gulf and funneling millions of rural migrants into the sprawling informal settlements of Karachi and Lahore.

Theoretical Foundations: Ravenstein, Lee, and Zelinsky's Models

The spatial dynamics of migration are illuminated by three foundational geographical theories: 1. E.G. Ravenstein's Laws of Migration (1885): Analyzing census data from Britain, Ravenstein formulated empirical laws that remain remarkably robust today: (a) most migrants travel only short distances, with migration volume decreasing as distance increases (distance decay); (b) migration occurs in a step-by-step fashion, moving from rural hamlets to market towns, then to secondary cities, and finally to major metropolitan hubs; (c) long-distance migrants preferentially head for major commercial and industrial centers; (d) rural dwellers are more migratory than urban residents; and (e) economic motives are the predominant driving force behind all migratory movements. 2. Everett S. Lee's Push-Pull Model (1966): Lee conceptualized migration as a systemic interaction between four variables: (a) factors associated with the area of origin ('push factors'—negative conditions repelling individuals, such as poverty, unemployment, or political persecution); (b) factors associated with the area of destination ('pull factors'—positive conditions attracting migrants, such as higher wages, civic amenities, and political freedoms); (c) 'intervening obstacles'—physical, legal, financial, and cultural barriers (e.g., physical distances, immigration visas, border walls, travel costs) that must be overcome; and (d) personal factors that modulate how an individual perceives these conditions. 3. Wilbur Zelinsky's Mobility Transition Model (1971): Paralleling the Demographic Transition Model (DTM), Zelinsky demonstrated that mobility patterns evolve systematically through economic modernization. Pre-industrial societies (Phase 1) exhibit minimal residential mobility; early developing societies undergoing population explosions (Phase 2, like Pakistan) experience massive rural-to-urban migration and high international emigration; while advanced post-industrial societies (Phase 4) experience high inter-urban mobility, suburbanization, and become major destinations for international immigration.

Internal Migration in Pakistan: The Great Rural-to-Urban Exodus

Within Pakistan, internal migration is overwhelmingly dominated by the rural-to-urban drift. Over the past three decades, millions of citizens have migrated from rural agricultural belts to major urban centers. This movement is driven by powerful rural push factors: extreme landlessness resulting from feudal agrarian structures, the progressive mechanization of agriculture which displaces tenant farmers (haris and muzareen), recurring climate shocks (such as

the devastating 2022 floods that submerged millions of acres in Sindh and Balochistan), and the near-total absence of quality healthcare and higher education in rural peripheries. Conversely, urban centers exert powerful economic pull factors: industrial employment, the expansive informal service economy (street vending, transportation, domestic labor), and social anonymity that allows individuals to escape oppressive rural caste and feudal hierarchies. Karachi represents the supreme national migration pole—a mega-agglomeration of nearly 19 million people that has absorbed millions of migrants from Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, southern Punjab, and rural Sindh. In Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, rapid internal migration flows from mountainous, resource-scarce districts (Dir, Swat, Kohistan, Karak) into the fertile, urbanized Peshawar-Nowshera-Mardan valley corridor, generating acute urban sprawl, traffic gridlock, and severe pressure on municipal water supplies.

International Labor Migration: The Persian Gulf Remittance Lifeline

Pakistan is one of the world's leading exporters of labor, with over nine million citizens registered as overseas workers by the Bureau of Emigration and Overseas Employment. Approximately 96% of these temporary economic migrants reside in the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) nations, primarily the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia (over 50%) and the United Arab Emirates (roughly 30%). This migratory corridor exhibits unique geographical characteristics: - It is overwhelmingly male-dominated, contractual, and circular: workers obtain temporary work visas (iqama/kafala system) without the possibility of naturalization or permanent settlement, returning to Pakistan upon the expiration of their contracts. - The economic impact of this corridor is monumental: overseas Pakistani workers send home between $28 billion and $31 billion annually in formal remittances. These funds represent Pakistan's largest single source of foreign exchange, outstripping total national merchandise exports and providing critical balance-of-payments stabilization. - At the regional and household level, particularly in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (districts such as Swat, Lower Dir, Mardan, and Swabi) and northern Punjab (Gujrat, Jhelum, Rawalpindi), Gulf remittances have revolutionized rural living standards. Remittance inflows finance modern pucca housing construction, private schooling for children, improved nutrition, and consumer goods. However, it also introduces distortions, fostering an artificial real estate bubble, discouraging local industrial entrepreneurship, and creating 'Dutch disease' effects where rural households become totally dependent on external transfers.

The High-Skilled Exodus ('Brain Drain') vs. The Afghan Refugee Imprint

Two additional migration flows profoundly alter Pakistan's human geography: - The High-Skilled Exodus (Brain Drain): Unlike the temporary blue-collar migration to the Gulf, emigration to OECD nations (United States, United Kingdom, Canada, Australia, European Union) consists predominantly of highly educated, skilled professionals—doctors, software engineers, data scientists, and university academics. In 2023 alone, official statistics indicated that over 800,000 skilled individuals left Pakistan due to economic stagflation, low public sector wages, and political instability. While these emigrants form influential diaspora communities abroad, this permanent intellectual drain severely undermines Pakistan's institutional capacity, healthcare delivery, and high-tech industrial modernization. - The Afghan Refugee Geography: For more than four decades following the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan in 1979, Pakistan has hosted one of the world's largest protracted refugee populations, historically peaking at over three million individuals. Concentrated predominantly in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (in refugee villages across Peshawar, Haripur, and Nowshera) and Balochistan (Quetta and Pishin), Afghan refugees have deeply reshaped local economies. They integrated heavily into commercial road transport, manual construction, wholesale fruit/vegetable markets, and carpet weaving. However, this prolonged demographic influx has also strained local municipal services, contributed to rapid deforestation in border districts, and generated complex security and bilateral diplomatic tensions.

Conclusion: Formulating an Integrated Spatial Migration Policy

In conclusion, migration in Pakistan is a powerful socio-spatial phenomenon that reflects the country's internal regional inequalities and its position in the global international division of labor. Migration is neither inherently positive nor negative; its net impact is mediated by public policy. To harness migration for national development, Pakistan must transition from reactive crisis management to proactive spatial planning. Domestically, the state must implement intermediate city growth strategies to redirect rural migrants away from choked megacities like Karachi and Lahore. Internationally, Pakistan must upskill its labor force—shifting from exporting low-wage manual labor to certified technical and vocational professionals—while creating institutional mechanisms and financial instruments (such as

diaspora bonds and SME venture funds) to channel overseas remittances into productive, job-creating industrial and infrastructural investments.

4. SCHOLARLY PERSPECTIVES & GEOGRAPHICAL AXIOMS TABLE

Scholar / Geographer	School of Thought / Paradigm	Quotable Philosophical Thesis / Axiom
Ernst Georg Ravenstein (1885)	Classical Migration Laws	*"Bad or oppressive laws, heavy taxation, an unattractive climate, all have produced and are still producing currents of migration, but none of these currents can compare in volume with that which arises from the desire inherent in most men to 'better' themselves in material respect."*
Everett S. Lee (1966)	Push-Pull Theory of Migration	*"Migration is a selective process; the characteristics of migrants are determined by the balance between the push of origin, the pull of destination, and the nature of intervening obstacles."*
Wilbur Zelinsky (1971)	Mobility Transition Hypothesis	*"There are definite, patterned regularities in the growth of personal mobility through space-time during the modernization process, paralleling the demographic transition."*
Michael P. Todaro (1969)	Rural-Urban Migration Economics	*"Rural-urban migration will continue as long as the expected urban income exceeds the average rural agricultural income, explaining persistent urban slum expansion despite high open urban unemployment."*
Hein de Haas (2010)	Migration and Development Theory	*"Migration is not a developmental failure, but an intrinsic, constituent part of broader social transformation and human capability expansion."*